

WEEK

1

Week 1 Study Guide

Channel Theory: Concept, Nomenclature, Flow of Qi

12 Meridians · 3 Circuits · Foundational Theory

This Document Contains:

What a channel is, and how it differs from a meridian and a collateral
Zang-Fu organ theory and the 12 Primary Meridians' full nomenclature
The Three Circuits (Outer/Anterior, Inner/Posterior, Middle) in full detail
Direction of Qi flow and exactly where paired meridians meet
The full 24-hour Meridian Clock and its clinical application
Dr. Zhang's Clinical Pearls + Quiz 1 Fundamentals

QUIZ 1 covers: Channel Theory (this week's material)

This is the foundation every later week builds on directly
No channel-specific points yet - LU/LI begin next week

Jonathan Centeno · D.AcHM Candidate · Sourced from Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture, VUIM Summer 2026

Channels, Meridians, and Collaterals

'Channels' (Jing-Luo) is the umbrella term covering BOTH Meridians (Jing, the primary pathways - like a river) AND Collaterals (Luo, the branches - smaller networks connecting meridians to tissues and organs).

The Full Channel System

- 12 Primary Meridians (Jing) - the main rivers
- 15 Collaterals (Luo) - 12 from each primary meridian's own Luo-connecting point, plus the Luo of Du Mai, Ren Mai, and the Spleen's Great Luo (Dabao)
- 12 Divergent Meridians - branch from the primary meridians, distribute on chest/abdomen/head, deepen the Zang-Fu relationship (detail taught later in the course)
- 12 Muscle (Sinew) Regions - distribution of the primary meridians into the muscular system
- 12 Cutaneous Regions - the most superficial layer, where channel Qi reflects on the skin
- 8 Extraordinary Vessels - Du, Ren, Chong, Dai, Yinwei, Yangwei, Yinqiao, Yangqiao; act as reservoirs of Qi and Blood, closely connected to the Kidney, regulating the primary meridians as needed (detail taught later)

This course's ten weeks build through this system in order: channel theory (this week), the 12 Primary Meridians one by one (Weeks 2-6), additional channels and regions (Week 7), the 8 Extraordinary Vessels (Week 8), and acupuncture points (Week 9). Everything after this week assumes this vocabulary is second nature.

Zang-Fu Organ Theory

Zang (Yin) Organs - 6 total

- Lung (LU)
- Spleen (SP)
- Heart (HT)
- Liver (LR)
- Kidney (KI)
- Pericardium (PC)

Fu (Yang) Organs - 6 total

- Large Intestine (LI)
- Stomach (ST)
- Small Intestine (SI)
- Bladder (BL)
- Gallbladder (GB)
- San Jiao (SJ)

Zang organs are solid/dense and considered Yin. Fu organs are hollow and considered Yang. Each of the 12 Primary Meridians pertains to exactly one of these 12 organs, and connects to its interior-exterior paired organ (its Zang-Fu partner).

The 3-Part Nomenclature System

1. Hand or Foot (location of the pathway)
2. Yin or Yang (nature / medial-lateral surface)
3. Zang or Fu (pertaining organ)

e.g. 'Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin', 'Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming'

Anterior = Taiyin(yin)/Yangming(yang); Posterior = Shaoyin(yin)/Taiyang(yang); Middle = Jueyin(yin)/Shaoyang(yang) - this naming is based on LOCATION (medial/lateral position on the limb), not organ function.

The First Question: Which Came First?

Which were discovered first: the channels, or the points?

The CHANNELS were discovered first, then the points. This is confirmed by the Mawangdui Silk Manuscripts (excavated from a Western Han Dynasty tomb): the silk texts describe channel pathways but do not yet reference specific points - meaning the pathway concept predates the point concept in the historical record.

Source: Dr. Zhang, Week 1 lecture (verbatim transcript) + Slide 13

Timeline

Origins

c. 2000+ years ago

Theoretical foundation laid in China; earliest surviving textual evidence is the Mawangdui Silk Manuscripts (Western Han Dynasty tomb), which describe the Yin and Yang meridians but predate point-specific texts.

Formalization

Zhou & Han Dynasties

The Huangdi Neijing (Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon) - read as two volumes, Su Wen (Basic Questions) and Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot) - details the location, properties, and uses of acupuncture points, laying the foundation of modern practice. This text marks the formal establishment of the Meridian System as composed of the 12 Primary Meridians.

Spread to East Asia

6th century CE

Channel theory and acupuncture practice spread to East Asian countries neighboring China.

Spread to the West

17th century onward

Acupuncture reached Europe and, later, North America.

Modern Recognition

Present day

Recognized by the WHO as an evidence-based complementary therapy and integrated into healthcare systems worldwide; modern research reinterprets meridians as networks integrating neural, circulatory, connective-tissue, and bioelectrical processes rather than fixed anatomical structures like nerves or blood vessels.

The Inner Canon Marks the Formation of Acupuncture Theory

The Huangdi Neijing (Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon) establishes the Meridian System as primarily composed of the 12 Primary Meridians, and harmonizes human health with natural principles (Yin-Yang), emphasizing preventive care and balance between body and mind.

History of Channels & Points in Books

- The “Inner Canon” marks the formation of acupuncture theory
- Establish the Meridian System primarily composed of the **twelve primary Meridians**
- Harmonizing human health with natural principles (**Yin-Yang**), emphasizing preventive care & balance between body & mind



《The yellow Emperor's Inner Canon》

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□□□□□ · The Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon · Source: Slide 15

The Formation of Meridian Theory (Slide 18)

□ Observation

Observation of stimulation induction and conduction (needle sensation, Qi).

□ Documentation

Summary of acupoint effects (Points -> The Line).

□ Classical text support

Ling Shu: “As for a man eight feet tall, his skin and flesh are right here: outwardly they can be measured, palpated, and examined; after death, they can be dissected and observed.”

□ Internal Qi flow

The phenomenon of internal Qi flow (the small cycle) discovered by ancient people in qigong and guided breathing practice.

The Modern Reframe: Neuroscience Explains, Doesn't Replace

A key point from lecture: acupuncture's mechanism is increasingly understood through neuroscience, not superseded by it. The reason acupuncture works isn't because of the ancient explanations themselves, but because the loci ancient clinicians selected are direct access points to the nervous system. In this framing, meridians can be understood as a combination of peripheral nerve pathways, arterial pathways, and myofascial referred-pain patterns - a map of favorable access points to the nervous system discovered empirically, centuries before that neuroscience existed to explain why they worked.

Quiz-Safe History Facts — Quick Recall List

- Channels were discovered BEFORE points (Mawangdui Silk Manuscripts describe pathways with no points yet).
- The Huangdi Neijing (Yellow Emperor's Inner Canon) is the classical text that formalized the 12 Primary Meridian system.
- Acupuncture is over 2,000 years old, tracing to the Zhou and Han Dynasties.
- The WHO recognizes acupuncture as an evidence-based complementary therapy today.
- Modern science reframes meridians as networks of nerve, circulatory, connective-tissue, and bioelectrical access points - it explains the mechanism, it doesn't disprove the system.

Full Reference Table

Ab	Name	Classification	Direction	Circuit
LU	Lung	Hand Taiyin	Chest -> Hand	Outer (Anterior)
LI	Large Intestine	Hand Yangming	Hand -> Head	Outer (Anterior)
ST	Stomach	Foot Yangming	Head -> Foot	Outer (Anterior)
SP	Spleen	Foot Taiyin	Foot -> Chest	Outer (Anterior)
HT	Heart	Hand Shaoyin	Chest -> Hand	Inner (Posterior)
SI	Small Intestine	Hand Taiyang	Hand -> Head	Inner (Posterior)
BL	Bladder	Foot Taiyang	Head -> Foot	Inner (Posterior)
KI	Kidney	Foot Shaoyin	Foot -> Chest	Inner (Posterior)
PC	Pericardium	Hand Jueyin	Chest -> Hand	Middle
SJ	San Jiao (Triple Burner)	Hand Shaoyang	Hand -> Head	Middle
GB	Gallbladder	Foot Shaoyang	Head -> Foot	Middle
LR	Liver	Foot Jueyin	Foot -> Chest	Middle

This is the single most important table in this document. Every week from here forward builds on knowing a channel's abbreviation, full classification, direction of flow, and which circuit it belongs to, instantly and without hesitation.

Limb Distribution - Yin AND Yang (Slide 27)

Dr. Zhang's slide showing exactly how the 12 channels are distributed on the limbs, with the full Yin+Yang table, color-coded arm/leg diagrams, and the Chinese terms.

Distribution of the twelve Main Meridians

Anterior view Posterior view

Yin meridian Yang meridian

Foot-Jueyin, Foot-Taiyin, Foot-Shaoyin

Twelve regular meridians:

Limbs: Medial aspect--*Yin* meridians
Lateral aspect--*Yang* meridians

- Anterior--*Taiyin--Yangming*
- Posterior--*Shaoyin--Taiyang*
- Middle--*Jueyin--Shaoyang*

Limbs (四肢)	Medial aspect (内侧) — Yin meridians (阴经)	Lateral aspect (外侧) — Yang meridians (阳经)
Anterior (前)	Taiyin (太阴)	Yangming (阳明)
Middle (中)	Jueyin (厥阴)	Shaoyang (少阳)
Posterior (后)	Shaoyin (少阴)	Taiyang (太阳)

The Liver Meridian of Foot-Jueyin ascends to an area 8 cun above the medial malleolus, where it runs across and behind the Spleen Meridian of Foot-Taiyin

Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides, Slide 27

On the HEAD and TRUNK, only the Yang channels get a 3-way anterior/posterior/lateral split (Yangming/Taiyang/ShaoYang) - Yin channels don't reach the head. On the trunk (chest/abdomen), all three Yin channels (Taiyin, Shaoyin, Jueyin) run together along the anterior aspect only - there's no separate Yin posterior or lateral position on the trunk the way there is on the limbs.

Cross-verified against Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture (AC300Week1.txt) and Slide 27 of her lecture deck.

Worked Example - All 12 Channels by Position

Cross-referencing the table above against the Full Reference Table: every channel's classification already names its limb position - you just have to recognize it.

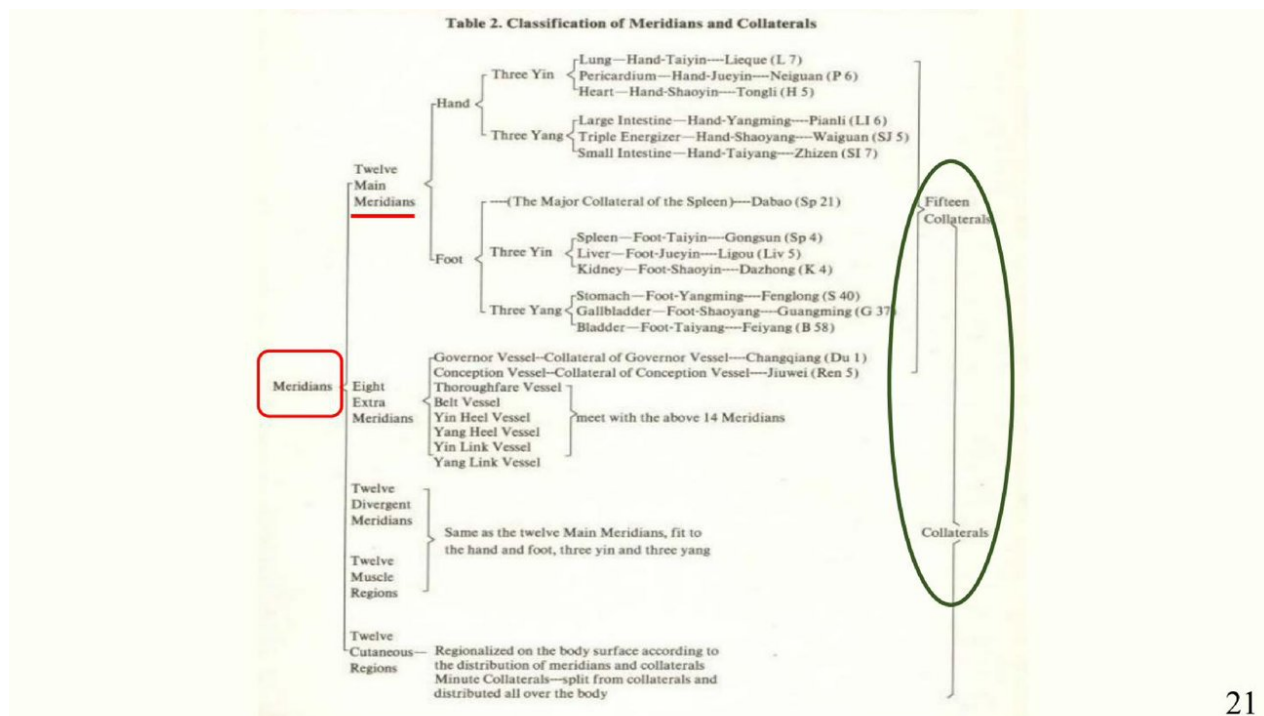
Ab	Name	Six-Meridian Name	Limb Position	Yin or Yang
LU	Lung	Taiyin	Anterior	Yin
LI	Large Intestine	Yangming	Anterior	Yang
ST	Stomach	Yangming	Anterior	Yang
SP	Spleen	Taiyin	Anterior	Yin
HT	Heart	Shaoyin	Posterior	Yin
SI	Small Intestine	Taiyang	Posterior	Yang
BL	Bladder	Taiyang	Posterior	Yang
KI	Kidney	Shaoyin	Posterior	Yin
PC	Pericardium	Jueyin	Middle/Lateral	Yin
SJ	San Jiao (Triple Burner)	Shaoyang	Middle/Lateral	Yang
GB	Gallbladder	Shaoyang	Middle/Lateral	Yang
LR	Liver	Jueyin	Middle/Lateral	Yin

Clinical Pearl from Slide 27

The Liver Meridian of Foot-Jueyin ascends to an area 8 cun above the medial malleolus, where it runs across and behind the Spleen Meridian of Foot-Taiyin - a named crossing point between the Middle and Anterior limb positions, worth remembering as a landmark.

Classification Tree (Slide 21)

Slide 21's classification table organizes the full channel system as one tree: the 12 Primary Meridians (Hand: 3 Yin + 3 Yang; Foot: 3 Yin + 3 Yang) sit at the center, branching into the 15 Collaterals (12 primary Luo-points + Du/Ren/Spleen's Great Luo), the 12 Divergent Meridians, and outward into the 12 Muscle (Sinew) Regions and 12 Cutaneous Regions - with the 8 Extraordinary Vessels running alongside as a separate reservoir system, sharing 2 members (Du Mai, Ren Mai) with the 14-meridian count some texts use.



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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides, Slide 21

Meridians (Jingmai) vs. Collaterals (Luomai)

Aspect	Meridians (Jingmai)	Collaterals (Luomai)
Meaning	Pathway	Network
Standing	Trunk	Branch
Distribution	Vertical line	Running amok (irregular, web-like)
Depth	Deep	Shallow
Number	Few (12 Primary)	Many (15 named + further branching)
Function	Leading - the pathways through which Qi and Blood circulate	Supplement and bond - promotes Qi and Blood circulation between meridians

Classical source cited on Slide 22: 经脉者，所以能决死生，处百病，调虚实，不可不通。 (“The meridians run through the interior; the branches running crosswise from them are the collaterals; and the branches of the collaterals are the grandchild-vessels.”)

Six-Meridian Names — Hand and Foot (Slide 25)

Nomenclature of the Meridians and Their Composition

	Yin Meridian Belong Zang	Yang Meridian Belong Fu
The Six Meridians of Hand	Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin, LU	Large Intestine Meridian of Hand-Yangming, LI
	Heart Meridian of Hand-Shaoyin, HT	Small Intestine Meridian of Hand-Taiyang, SI
	Pericardium Meridian of Hand-Jueyin, PC	Triple Energizer Meridian of Hand-Shaoyang, TE
The Six Meridians of Foot	Spleen Meridian of Foot-Taiyin, SP	Stomach Meridian of Foot-Yangming, ST
	Kidney Meridian of Foot-Shaoyin, KI	Bladder Meridian of Foot-Taiyang, BL
	Liver Meridian of Foot-Jueyin, LR	Gallbladder Meridian of Foot-Shaoyang, GB

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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides, Slide 25 — the full official name of every one of the 12 channels

Quick Self-Test

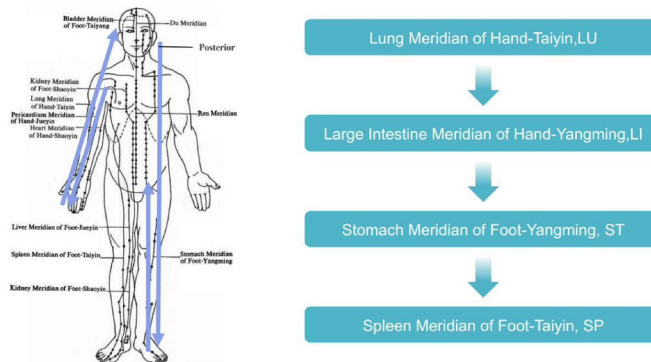
Cover the table above and try to write out all 12 full official names from memory (e.g. 'Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin, LU') before checking your answers against it. This is the exact naming format tested on quizzes.

The Anterior Circuit (Anterior)

Taiyin / Yangming

LU (chest->hand) -> LI (hand->head) -> ST (head->foot) -> SP (foot->chest)

The Anterior Circuit



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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

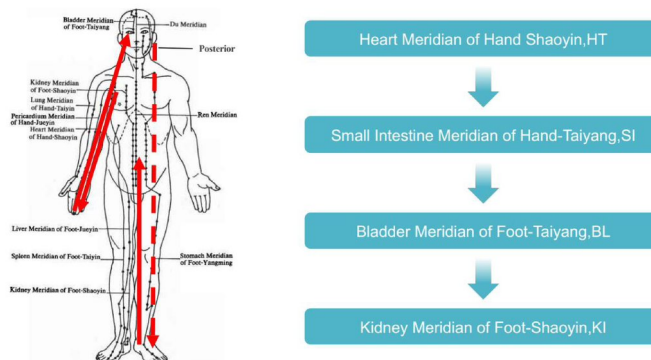
Memory hook: Taiyin/Yangming = greatest Yin/Yang - these run the most anterior, most "outward-facing" line on the body, the same way Yangming is the most exterior/superficial of the three Yang stages.

The Posterior Circuit (Posterior)

Shaoyin / Taiyang

HT (chest->hand) -> SI (hand->head) -> BL (head->foot) -> KI (foot->chest)

The Posterior Circuit



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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

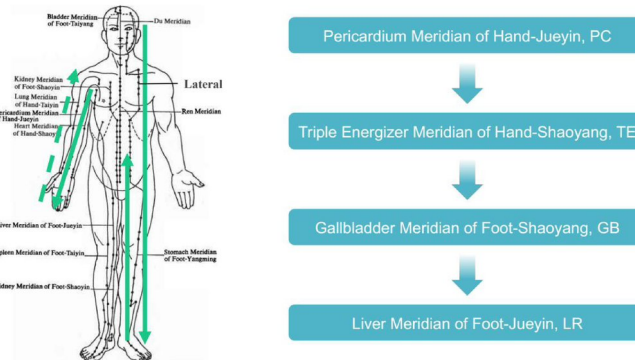
Memory hook: Shaoyin/Taiyang = "lesser Yin" paired with the most posterior Yang - HT and KI are your deepest, most vital Yin organs, matching their posterior/interior pathway.

The Middle Circuit (Middle)

Jueyin / Shaoyang

PC (chest->hand) -> SJ (hand->head) -> GB (head->foot) -> LR (foot->chest)

The Middle Circuit



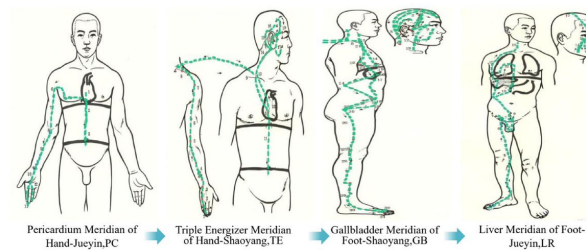
35

Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

Memory hook: Jueyin/ShaoYang = the "hinge" pair - literally the middle/lateral position on the limb, and functionally the hinge between Yin and Yang in six-stage theory.

Middle Circuit, Whole-Body View

The Middle Circuit



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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides

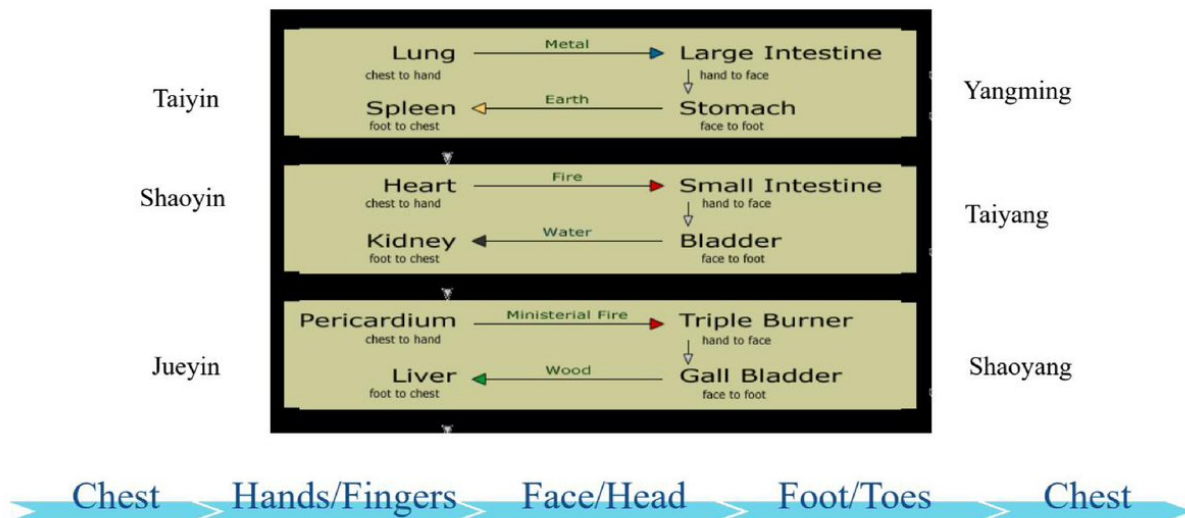
Why PC/SJ/GB/LR are called the "Middle" Circuit, not a 3rd Yin/Yang pair:

They occupy the middle/lateral line on the limb (Jueyin/ShaoYang) - distinct from anterior (Taiyin/Yangming) and posterior (Shaoyin/Taiyang). Same 4-channel structure, 3rd position.

All Three Circuits, Element-Coded, One Diagram (Slide 37)

The Outer Circuit's Yang partner is Yangming; the Inner Circuit's is Taiyang; the Middle Circuit's is Shaoyang. This single lecture diagram shows all 12 channels grouped into their 3 circuits with their 5-Element colors, plus the full loop: Chest -> Hands/Fingers -> Face/Head -> Foot/Toes -> Chest.

Three Main Circuits in the Flow of Qi



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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides, Slide 37

This is the single best all-in-one memory diagram in the Week 1 material.

If you can redraw this diagram from memory - all 12 abbreviations, elements, and both circuit directions - you have mastered this week's core content.

Direction of Qi Flow

Yin meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the HAND

Yang meridians of the FOOT

Yin meridians of the FOOT

Chest -> Hand

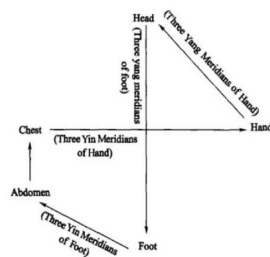
Hand -> Head

Head -> Foot

Foot -> Chest/Abdomen

This four-part rule is the single most repeated fact across every lecture and quiz review in this course. Memorize it as one continuous loop: chest to hand, hand to head, head to foot, foot to chest - and back to chest again, completing the cycle.

Circulation of the twelve main Meridians



The twelve main meridians circulate in certain rules.

1. Three yin meridians of hand run from the chest to the hand and converge on the ends of fingers with three yang meridians of hand in exterior and interior relation.
2. Three yang meridians of hand ascend from the ends of fingers to the head where they connect with three yang meridians of foot.
3. Three yang meridians of foot descend from the head to the ends of toes where they join three yin meridians of foot;
4. three yin meridians of foot ascend from the toes to the abdomen and chest in which they meet three yin meridians of hand.

<https://tcmwiki.com/wiki/meridians/circulation-rules-of-the-twelve-main-meridians>

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Source: Dr. Zhang's Week 1 lecture slides, Slide 29

Where Paired Meridians Meet

Hand Yin meets Hand Yang, at the FINGERS

e.g. LU7's branch meets LI1 at the index finger

Hand Yang meets Foot Yang, at the FACE

e.g. LI ends at LI20, ST begins there

Foot Yang meets Foot Yin, at the TOES

e.g. ST ends at ST45, SP begins at SP1

Foot Yin meets Hand Yin, at the CHEST

completes the full 12-channel loop back to the next circuit

The 3 Functions of Meridians — With Classical Citations (Slide 38)

Transporting

Transport Qi and Blood to nourish the organs, skin, muscles, tendons, and bones; keep Yin-Yang in harmony throughout the body.

Ling Shu, Ch. 47:

“The meridians and collaterals transport blood and Qi to adjust Yin and Yang, nourish tendons and bones, and improve joint function.”

Resisting (Defending)

Defend the body against disease - meridians help resist pathogens and reflect symptoms/signs when something is wrong.

Ling Shu, Ch. 71:

“When the lung and heart are involved in a pathogenic invasion, the pathogenic Qi lingers in both elbows; when the liver is involved, it lingers in both axillae; when the spleen is involved, it stays in both groins; when the kidney is involved, it stays in both popliteal fossae.”

Treatment

Transmit needling sensation and regulate deficiency and excess conditions - the basis for using meridians and points clinically.

Ling Shu, Ch. 5 / Ch. 9:

“The key point in acupuncture treatment is to know how to regulate Yin and Yang.” (Ch. 5) / “Acupuncture treatment must aim at regulating the flow of Qi.” (Ch. 9)

FUNCTIONS OF THE MERIDIANS

A. Transporting *qi* and blood and regulating *yin* and *yang*.

Yellow Emperor Inner Classic, Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot - Chapter 47):

“The meridians and collaterals transport blood and qi to adjust yin and yang, nourish tendons and bones, and improve joint function.”

B. Resisting pathogens and reflecting symptoms and signs.

Yellow Emperor Inner Classic, Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot - Chapter 71):

“When the lung and heart are involved in a pathogenic invasion, the pathogenic qi lingers in both elbows; when the liver is involved, it lingers in both axillae; when the spleen is involved, it stays in both groins; when the kidney is involved, it stays in both popliteal fossae.”

C. Transmitting needling sensation and regulating deficiency and excess conditions.

Yellow Emperor Inner Classic, Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot - Chapter 5):

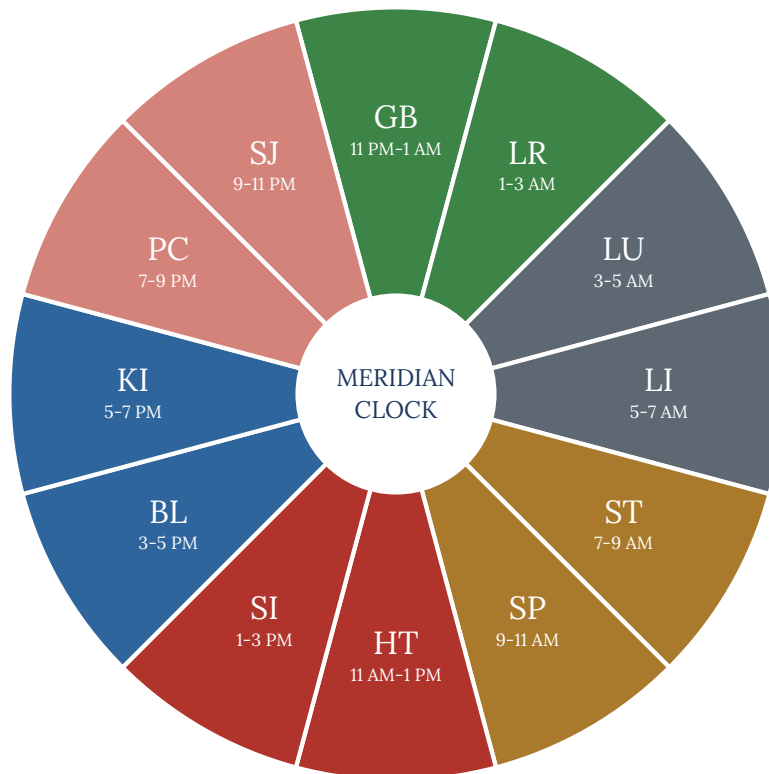
“The key point in acupuncture treatment is to know how to regulate yin and yang.”

Yellow Emperor Inner Classic, Ling Shu (Miraculous Pivot - Chapter 9):

“Acupuncture treatment must aim at regulating the flow of qi.”

The Meridian Clock (24-Hour Cycle)

Each meridian has a two-hour period of peak activity, following the same order the meridians connect to each other. Dr. Zhang's own clinical example: to treat a Large Intestine dysfunction, consider its 5-7 AM active window; symptoms that flare at a specific time of day can point directly to which channel is involved.



Metal (LU/LI) · Earth (ST/SP) · Fire (HT/SI) · Water (BL/KI) · Ministerial Fire (PC/SJ) · Wood (GB/LR)

Dr. Zhang's Clinical Pearls — Direct from Lecture

The Meridian Clock Has Real Clinical Use

Dr. Zhang's own example: if you want to treat a Large Intestine dysfunction, consider timing treatment around 5-7 AM, LI's active period. Symptoms that flare at a specific time of day can point directly to which channel is involved.

Channels Is a Bigger Category Than Meridians

A student asked this directly in lecture: 'meridians' specifically means the 12 Primary Meridians, while 'channels' is the whole system - meridians AND collaterals together. When a question says 'channels,' don't assume it only means the 12 primary pathways.

Draw It, Don't Just Read It

Dr. Zhang's own studying advice, repeated multiple times in lecture: draw each circuit's four meridians by hand, more than once, rather than only reading the sequence. This is also the format of the homework assignments for this course.

Same-Named Channels on Opposite Limbs Communicate

Per lecture: arm and leg channels of the same name (e.g., Hand Taiyin LU and Foot Taiyin SP) communicate with one another. A problem in one can sometimes be addressed by treating points on its same-name partner.

The Extraordinary Vessels Are Reservoirs, Not Organs

The 8 Extraordinary Vessels aren't directly linked to a specific Zang-Fu organ the way the 12 Primary Meridians are. They act as reservoirs of Qi and Blood, closely tied to the Kidney, releasing or absorbing as the primary meridians need.

Quiz 1 Fundamentals

Key Terms

- Channel (Jing-Luo) = Meridians + Collaterals (the whole system)
- Meridian (Jing) = one of the 12 Primary pathways - 'like a river'
- Collateral (Luo) = a branch off a meridian's Luo-connecting point - 'like a branch'
- 12 Meridians + 15 Collaterals + 12 Divergent + 12 Sinew + 12 Cutaneous + 8 Extraordinary Vessels = the full channel system

Nomenclature

- 3-part name: Hand/Foot + Yin/Yang + Zang/Fu
- 6 Zang (Yin) organs: Lung, Spleen, Heart, Liver, Kidney, Pericardium
- 6 Fu (Yang) organs: Large Intestine, Stomach, Small Intestine, Bladder, Gallbladder, San Jiao

Circulation

- Yin meridians of the hand: chest -> hand
- Yang meridians of the hand: hand -> head
- Yang meridians of the foot: head -> foot
- Yin meridians of the foot: foot -> chest/abdomen
- Repeat this sequence until automatic - it's the single most tested fact in the course

Circuits

- Outer/Anterior: LU -> LI -> ST -> SP (Taiyin/Yangming)
- Inner/Posterior: HT -> SI -> BL -> KI (Shaoyin/Taiyang)
- Middle: PC -> SJ -> GB -> LR (Jueyin/ShaoYang)

Functions

- Transporting: nourish organs, skin, muscles, tendons, bones; keep Yin-Yang harmony
- Resisting: defend against disease, reflect symptoms when pathogens invade
- Treatment: transmit needling sensation, regulate deficiency/excess

Dr. Zhang's Week 1 homework: draw the circulation, direction, and distribution of the Lung Meridian of Hand-Taiyin specifically - the same drawing standard applies to every meridian going forward.